

One Reform Divided the Elite, the Other Replaced It

Electoral Reform and Parliamentary Speech in the
Belgian *Belle Époque*, 1880–1912

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ABSTRACT

What makes a governing elite pull apart? Explanations of elite polarization emphasize demand-side drivers acting on the electorate, while the electoral institutions that structure competition figure as objects of elite choice rather than as causes of elite behaviour. We ask whether electoral reform can itself divide a governing elite, using two Belgian reforms that fall on opposite sides of that divide: plural manhood suffrage (1894), which reshaped the electorate, and proportional representation (1900), which reshaped how votes become seats. We measure elite polarization directly from parliamentary speech, applying the leave-out partisanship estimator of Gentzkow et al. (2019) to all plenary debates of both houses, 490,002 interventions over three decades. Identification exploits Belgium’s imperfect bicameralism as a difference in exposure: both houses were returned by the same enlarged electorate, but candidacy rules the reforms left untouched kept the new competitor out of the upper house, so the Chamber debated with socialists in it and the Senate did not; the contrast nets out the national shocks common to both. The reaction is asymmetric. Plural suffrage produced a rise in Catholic–Liberal distinctiveness that is timed to the reform—the 1894 break is the largest of the fifteen feasible cutoff dates—persistent to the end of the window, and driven by the within-politician adaptation of sitting members—Catholic incumbents in particular—rather than by turnover; the divergence is overwhelmingly within-topic, and largest on labour and social policy. Proportional representation did not move that distance. What it moved was the composition of the chamber: the post-1900 divergence loads on entrants rather than on sitting members, the coal districts return Catholic members who had all but vanished from them after 1894—seven deputies between the reforms, thirty-nine after—and our companion study finds the same recomposition channel on the salience of labour (Graziani & Vanschoonbeek, 2026). We do not read the flat Catholic–Liberal coefficient as an estimated zero: on that axis the bicameral contrast is attenuated by construction, so what we can say is that the rule change left no trace on the distance between the governing parties while visibly changing who sat between them. The two reforms acted on different margins. Enfranchisement changed how the sitting elite spoke; proportionality changed who was there to speak.

Keywords: elite polarization, electoral reform, electoral institutions, plural suffrage, proportional representation, bicameralism, parliamentary speech, text-as-data.

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References

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